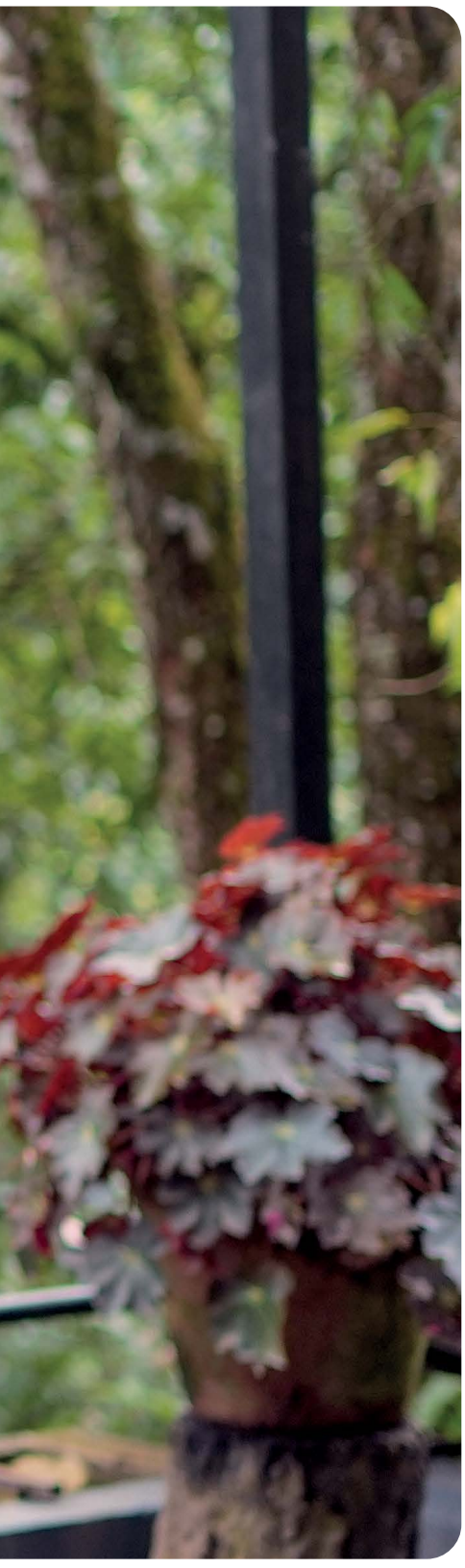
TRIBENY RAI, 35
Filmmaker
Sikkim

A Voice from the Margins



Growing up in Nandok, a quiet village 19 kilometres from Gangtok, Tribeny Rai knew early what it meant to be a girl. It did not matter that she came from a family of four sisters, and her schoolteacher and parents never discriminated between them, because the people around her constantly reminded her where women belonged. At gatherings, younger male cousins would be blessed before her during traditional ceremonies, even though it was customary to follow the descending order of age. Boys, she was told, would carry forward the family legacy, while girls would get married and leave. Coming back from work, it was she who was expected to prepare food while the boys rested. Those seemingly ordinary moments left extraordinary scars.

Instead of accepting these norms, Rai decided to challenge them. "It was essential, as a woman, to choose a profession that helps me earn a sense of power and authority," she says. She first dreamt of becoming a journalist and worked briefly as a reporter with a local newspaper. Then, she discovered filmmaking. Cinema, she realised, allowed her to create entire worlds.

That path was anything but easy. In Sikkim, secure government jobs remained the accepted aspiration, while filmmaking, especially in Nepali, offered neither financial certainty nor an established industry. Rai joined the Satyajit Ray Film and Television Institute and then worked with Doordarshan, making documentaries and TV shows. Every rupee earned—and even part of her mother's retirement savings—went into financing her debut feature, *Shape of Momo*. It was a gamble few investors were willing to take: a Nepali-language film about women from the hills by a first-time director. But the risk paid off. The film travelled globally and established Rai as one of the most promising voices from the Himalayas. ■

— Arkamoy Datta Majumdar

WHAT MAKES HER A SHERO

Tribeny burst onto the global scene last year with her debut feature, *Shape of Momo*, about a woman's return to her patriarchal village, the script doubling as a thesis on gender, family and belonging in the Eastern Himalayas

HER TAKE

"I got introduced to world cinema at the Satyajit Ray Film and Television Institute and fell in love with the director's work. When I first saw the Apu Trilogy, I couldn't believe how personal Ray could make the Bengal countryside for me"